THE BATTLE OF BEACHY HEAD

The War of the League of Augsburg, sparked by the Protestant William of Orange's accession to the English throne in 1688, set the navy of Louis XIV's Catholic France against the formidable maritime power of the English and the Dutch. On June 21, 1690, the French Mediterranean fleet commanded by the Marquis de Châteaurenault sailed into Brest to join the Atlantic fleet commanded by the Comte de Tourville. This combined fleet had a local numerical advantage over its enemies, for the English had dangerously dispersed their forces, with detachments in the Mediterranean and the Irish Sea, as well as numerous ships on convoy escort duties.

Tourville entered the English Channel with 70 magnificent ships of the line, intending to attack the depleted English in their anchorage at Spithead. But English admiral Arthur Herbert, the 1st Earl of Torrington, did not wait to be attacked, advancing cautiously westward along the south coast of England, where he was joined by a squadron of 22 Dutch ships under Cornelis Evertsen. Encountering the French off the white cliffs of Beachy Head, Torrington held the weather gage and at first used it to avoid battle with a superior force. But the English royal council rejected this negative posture and ordered Torrington to attack.

Battle was joined on the morning of July 10. The two fleets formed up conventionally in line ahead. Since the French ships of the line outnumbered the English and the Dutch, their line was longer, a problem the allies failed to address. The Dutch squadron forming the allied van boldly sailed forward to engage the enemy but failed to reach the front of the French line, the foremost Dutch ship exchanging broadsides with the eighth French ship. Châteaurenault, commanding the French van in the 110-gun *Dauphin Royal*, ordered the Marquis de Villette-Mursay to double back with the seven front ships down the lee side of the Dutch, who were caught between two lines of fire. When Tourville, commanding the center in his three-decker flagship *Soleil Royal*, succeeded in slipping some of his ships into a gap that had opened up between the hesitant Torrington's center and the van, the Dutch ships were surrounded.

The French rear squadron, vigorously attacked by the third English squadron under Sir Ralph Delaval, took some heavy punishment. Three French ships had to withdraw from the line, one with its poop blown off when cartridges exploded on deck. But their losses were as nothing to those suffered by the Dutch. Only one ship, *Friesland*, struck and was sunk, but all were shattered, their decks littered with the dead and wounded. In the afternoon the wind dropped and the ships drifted with the current. As the tide began to ebb, Torrington gave the signal to anchor. Caught unawares, the French drifted away from the allied ships, bringing the day's fighting to an end.

The aftermath brought controversy on both sides. Torrington fled for the Thames, abandoning any ships too badly damaged to follow (all but one of them Dutch). Tourville contented himself with finishing off these defenseless wrecks and then, after sacking the port of Teignmouth, returned to France to unload his wounded and refit his mauled ships. Torrington was imprisoned in the Tower of London. Although a court martial cleared him of treachery, he was dismissed from the service. Tourville was also criticized for failing to pursue the defeated English. His great victory failed to have any decisive consequence.



Victory at Bévéziers
This French medal commemorating the Battle of Beachy Head (Bévéziers, in French) depicts Louis XIV as Neptune ruling the seas.

WAR OF THE LEAGUE OF AUGSBURG



BATTLE OF BEACHY HEAD

Date	July 10, 1690
Location	Off Sussex, southern England
Result	French victory

COMBATANTS

FRANCE	ENGLAND DUTCH REPUBLIC

COMMANDERS

Comte de Tourville	Earl of Torrington

FORCES

Ships: 70 ships of the line	Ships: 56 ships of the line

LOSSES

Men: none Ships: none	Men: unknown Ships: 17 ships of the line

Dutch ship ablaze
A Dutch ship catches fire after sustained bombardment from the French. The battle saw the complete destruction of the Dutch fleet that formed the van.